India and Afghanistan on the morning of 8 October 2005. The quake registered a magnitude of 7.6 on the Richter Scale and its epicenter was located near Muzaffarabad; Pakistan-administered Kashmir, the NWFP, northern Punjab and Indian-administered Kashmir were the areas most affected. Delivery of humanitarian assistance was constrained by the mountainous terrain, cold weather and damaged or destroyed civilian infrastructure. Over 73,000 people died, an additional 69,000 were injured and 2.8 million left homeless in Pakistan. Another 1,300 people were killed in Indian-administered Kashmir, with more than 6,000 injured and over 150,000 made homeless.[64]

Although the army officially took the lead in relief efforts, in some areas jihadi groups were among the first on the scene. Years spent training in the area meant they were familiar with the terrain and also had grassroots networks in place that enabled them to reach victims quickly. It also meant they had well-equipped facilities near the quake site.[65] A number of their own cadres were killed, and approximately fifteen training camps were buried by landslides or otherwise destroyed by the earthquake.[66] The militants who survived quickly laid down their arms and picked up relief goods, carrying them to the remote areas they had come to know so well. The army provided logistical support, including helicopters, to help jihadi outfits engaged in the relief efforts. At least seventeen banned outfits were involved in either the immediate relief effort or reconstruction work later undertaken. A number of these operated under the banner of, or in coordination with, above-ground NGOs. Together they managed thirty-seven of the seventy-three camps operating either in or around Muzaffarabad and had a presence in every affected district of Pakistan-administered Kashmir.[67] Owing to the need to deliver aid as rapidly as possible, the UN and international NGOs worked with militants who were already in place.

JuD channeled considerable resources toward providing assistance through its relief wing Idarah Khidmat-e-Khalq: in Muzaffarabad it was treating patients within thirty minutes of the quake. Within thirty-six hours, the group had opened a fully functioning field hospital there and a second one in the Mansehra District [in the NWFP] where training camps have been located for a number of years. It also set up surgical centers, mobile dispensaries, mobilized its ambulance service (claimed to be the second